very bad in the data presented at the conference," an attendee told the news website NRG. "They sell Israel in this way, 'we have girls in bikinis, we have beaches, we have beer and bars; come to us.' And it doesn't work."

"Welcome to Israel's Vietnam"

In the winter of 1987 and 1988, as the first intifada erupted in Israel and the occupied territories, Albert Vorspan wrote a series of notes in his diary. Vorspan was the senior vice president of the Union of American Hebrew Congregations (now the Union for Reform Judaism), and a committed Zionist. But he was deeply troubled by what he called the "harvest of rage" on his television screen each night, an eruption that revealed the "political and moral bankruptcy of Israeli policy." It also revealed something else to Vorspan: the extent to which support for Israel had become, in his words, a "surrogate faith" for American Jews.

> This is the downside of the euphoric mood after the Six-Day War, when we felt ten feet tall. Now, suffering under the shame and stress of pictures of Israeli brutality televised nightly, we want to crawl into a hole. This is the price we pay for having made of Israel an icon—a surrogate faith, surrogate synagogue, surrogate God. Israel could not withstand our romantic idealization.[5]

It is a myth that American Jews are a monolithic bloc when it comes to Israel, though they used to be. Before 1967, the community's attitude could be best characterized as indifferent. Only a few hundred people emigrated each year, and financial support for the newly-established state quickly dried up, dropping by more than half by the end of Israel's first decade. The 1967 war changed that. It brought a sense of pride over Israel's overwhelming victory—along with, ironically, a paralyzing fear over Israel's perceived vulnerability. J. J. Goldberg, the editor of *The Forward*, noted the paradox in his 1997 book *Jewish Power*. "The Six-Day War demonstrated that Israel was more secure than anyone had dreamed," he wrote. "What the American Jewish community learned from the war was the reverse: that Israel might be destroyed at any moment." Support for pro-Israel groups surged, and tens of thousands of American Jews voted with their feet; immigration to Israel from North America climbed from 826 people in 1968 to 8,122 three years later, a tenfold increase.

But the unanimity was short-lived. The Likud party came to power in 1977, and liberal American Jews quickly began to criticize its policy of